

**THE JAPA' SYNDROME AND ITS EFFECT ON NATIONAL
ECONOMY: THE WAY FORWARD**

Abstract

This essay explores the multifaceted phenomenon known as the ‘Japa’ Syndrome, delving into its historical context, definition, and contributing factors. Additionally, it investigates the statistical impact of this syndrome on the national economy and its far-reaching implications.

Furthermore, it highlights the noteworthy achievement of the Chartered Institute of Personnel Management in addressing the Japa Syndrome in Nigeria. Finally, this essay presents meaningful solutions to the problems arising from this phenomenon. Through this comprehensive investigation, the essay aims to foster a deeper understanding of the Japa Syndrome and put forth solutions for a brighter future for our country.

Keywords: Japa Syndrome, CIPM

**THE 2023 CHARTERED INSTITUTE OF PERSONNEL MANAGEMENT OF
NIGERIA (CIPM) ANNUAL ESSAY COMPETITION**

**THE JAPA' SYNDROME AND ITS EFFECT ON NATIONAL ECONOMY: THE
WAY FORWARD**

INTRODUCTION

Article 13, Section 2, of the Universal Declaration of Human Rights states, “Everyone has the right to leave any country, including his own, and to return to his country.” This statement agrees with the Nigerian constitution on the right to freedom of movement. However, when many of our brightest minds and skilled professionals leave the country in large numbers, this raises concerns about the health of the economy. This prompted a question about what should be done to address the issues produced by the Japa Syndrome while keeping our economy strong. Thus, the purpose of this essay is to provide an overview of the historical context and the definition of the term 'Japa,' the factors that contribute to the Japa Syndrome, the statistical impact of the Japa Syndrome on the national economy, the consequences of the Japa Syndrome on the national economy, the achievements of the Chartered Institute of Personnel Management in addressing the Japa Syndrome in Nigeria, and how we can solve the problem caused by the Japa Syndrome.

THE HISTORICAL CONTEXT AND THE DEFINITION OF THE TERM ‘JAPA’

“Japa” is a Yoruba word meaning “to run, flee, or escape.” It has come to symbolize the aspirations of young Nigerians who aspire to leave the country in pursuit of a better life.

In layman's terms, the term "Japa Syndrome" refers to a phenomenon where many Nigerians want to leave their country in search of a better life or opportunities elsewhere. It

is like a strong desire among these individuals to run away or escape from their current circumstances and seek a brighter future in another place, often because they believe they can achieve more or have a better quality of life abroad.

Having established an understanding of the 'Japa Syndrome' and its underlying factors, let's shift our attention to the driving forces behind this desire to emigrate.

THE FACTORS CONTRIBUTING TO THE JAPA SYNDROME

There is no doubt that mass migration harms the economy and other aspects of a country's life. But what are the triggers? What could make Nigerians weather the storms of foreign travel and abandon their fatherland?

To comprehensively explore the 'Japa Syndrome' and the reasons behind the yearning to seek better prospects abroad, I will examine five key contributing factors. Nigerian youths' desire for prosperity, low standard of living, weak economy, dearth of employment opportunities, and mounting insecurity are the causes of emigration among Nigerians.

To begin with, the desire for prosperity is one of the factors contributing to the Japa Syndrome. Nigerians often aspire to a more prosperous life, seeking better income and opportunities. For instance, many young Nigerians dream of emigrating to countries like Canada, where they believe they can achieve a higher standard of living and financial stability. The promise of higher-paying jobs and a stronger economy abroad drives this desire for prosperity.

Low standards of living are another key contributing factor to the Japa Syndrome. The relatively low standard of living in Nigeria, characterised by inadequate access to basic services such as healthcare and education, contributes to migration. For example, the lack of accessible and quality healthcare in some regions leads individuals to consider leaving

Nigeria for countries with better healthcare systems, where they can ensure their well-being and that of their families.

Another critical factor contributing to the Japa Syndrome is a weak economy. Nigeria has faced economic challenges, including high inflation and fluctuating currency values. These economic issues can make it difficult for Nigerians to achieve financial stability. As a result, they may choose to emigrate to countries with more stable economies.

Also, a significant factor contributing to the Japa Syndrome that cannot be overlooked is the dearth of employment opportunities. High levels of underemployment and unemployment in Nigeria are significant factors behind Japa. Many Nigerians, despite their qualifications, struggle to find suitable jobs. For instance, a university graduate might work in a low-paying, unrelated job or remain unemployed due to a lack of opportunities, which can lead to frustration and the decision to seek better employment prospects abroad.

Last but not least is the pressing issue of insecurity, which is also a factor contributing to the Japa Syndrome. Insecurity, including issues such as terrorism, kidnappings, and communal violence, can create an environment of fear and uncertainty. Nigerians may opt to leave in search of safer surroundings.

After examining the factors that contribute to the 'Japa Syndrome,' let's evaluate the statistical impact the phenomenon has on the national economy.

THE STATISTICAL IMPACT OF THE JAPA' SYNDROME ON NATIONAL ECONOMY

In investigating the impact of the Japa Syndrome on the national economy, I discovered a series of interrelated implications affecting workforce dynamics and government finances.

The long-term effect for the country is that the majority of the people who are migrating or planning to are the youths, who constitute the productive population of the country. A recent survey from the Nigeria Social Cohesion Survey revealed that seven out of ten Nigerians are willing to relocate to other countries for various reasons, with a good number of them recording success. Today, there is still an increasing rate of an emerging urge to leave Nigeria among the old and the young. (Nigeria Social Cohesion Survey, 2022)

Also, last year, the Nigerian Association of Resident Doctors revealed that about 50 per cent of Nigerian doctors had already found their way out of the country. The University College Hospital, Ibadan, Oyo State, also noted that more than 600 of its clinical workers have resigned from their appointments, while the Lagos State University Teaching Hospital disclosed that more than 150 nurses have resigned from their appointments with the tertiary hospital (Nigerian Association of Resident Doctors, 2022).

In July 2022, the Association of Nigerian Students in Europe revealed that Europe alone has more than three million Nigerians enrolled in different higher institutions of learning. A survey also indicates that 89.87 per cent of Nigerian youths prefer to study at a university outside the country (Association of Nigerian Students, 2022).

In 2022, the unemployment rate in Nigeria is estimated to reach 33 percent. This figure was projected to be 32.5 per cent in the preceding year. Chronological data show that the unemployment rate in Nigeria has increased constantly in the past few years (Ogungbile, 2023)

These statistics paint a clear picture of the challenges facing Nigeria's workforce and economy. Amidst these concerning statistics and the evident trend of emigration, it is crucial to examine the consequences of the Japa Syndrome on the national economy.

THE CONSEQUENCES OF THE JAPA' SYNDROME ON NATIONAL ECONOMY

The impact of the Japa syndrome on the national economy has resulted in several consequences on the national economy that range from reduced labour force participation, brain drain, revenue loss, loss of innovation, negative perception of the country, and long-term economic uncertainty.

To begin with, reduced labour force participation is one of the consequences of Japa syndrome on the national economy. Many Nigerians seeking to leave the country for better opportunities often result in a decreased labour force, impacting the country's workforce and productivity. In the health sector, many Nigerian healthcare workers have emigrated to countries like the United Kingdom and Canada due to better working conditions and higher pay, resulting in shortages of medical personnel in Nigerian hospitals.

Brain drain is another consequence of Japa syndrome on the national economy. The departure of skilled and educated individuals can lead to a "brain drain," where Nigeria loses its intellectual capital and talent to other countries. Several Nigerian universities have reported a decline in the number of qualified teaching staff as professors and researchers opt for academic positions abroad, impacting the quality of higher education.

Another consequence of Japa syndrome on the national economy is revenue loss. Reduced tax contributions from those who leave, along with potential decreases in foreign direct investment, can strain government revenues. Foreign companies may hesitate to invest in Nigeria due to concerns about the emigration trend, potentially reducing foreign direct investment and economic growth.

Another effect of the Japa syndrome on the national economy is a loss of innovation. The departure of creative minds from Nigeria may impede the development of new technology and solutions. Scientists and researchers from Nigeria who have fled may make

exciting discoveries in other nations, while Nigeria misses out on possible scientific advances.

Another consequence of Japa syndrome on the national economy is a negative perception of the country. Mass migration of our people in a desperate manner would make foreigners form unfavourable and unrealistic collective opinions about Nigeria. Our citizens would also be perceived abroad as those who had no good future in their homelands till they migrated.

Finally, long-term economic uncertainty is another consequence of Japa syndrome on the national economy. The uncertainty surrounding the future of the country and the sustainability of its economy may deter foreign investment and economic growth. A decline in foreign investment in Nigeria due to uncertainty about the emigration trend has resulted in a slower rate of economic growth compared to neighbouring countries. Also, economic instability caused by the 'Japa' Syndrome can discourage local entrepreneurs from starting businesses or making long-term investments in Nigeria's economy.

In my analysis of the long-term economic uncertainties resulting from the 'Japa' Syndrome, it is crucial to recognize the significant role that the Chartered Institute of Personnel Management has played in addressing this challenge within Nigeria.

THE ACHIEVEMENT OF THE CHARTERED INSTITUTE OF PERSONNEL MANAGEMENT IN ADDRESSING THE JAPA SYNDROME IN NIGERIA

The Institute was chartered by Decree No. 58 of 1992 and charged with the responsibility of regulating the practice of Human Resource Management in Nigeria.

Over the years, the Chartered Institute of Personnel Management has played a vital role in addressing the 'Japa' Syndrome and its impact on the national economy. Through their commitment to promoting excellence in people management, optimizing human potential,

and standardizing and regulating human resource management practices, CIPM has been instrumental in cultivating a skilled and productive workforce that can drive economic growth within Nigeria.

Furthermore, the initiative of fostering intellectual growth and research acumen among Nigerian students through their annual essay competition has given me and many other students across Nigerian universities and polytechnics the privilege to contribute our insights on this timely and crucial subject matter.

CIPM achievements in these areas contribute significantly to mitigating the brain drain phenomenon and charting a way forward toward economic prosperity for our nation. Building on these achievements, let's now explore actionable steps for addressing and resolving the challenges posed by the 'Japa' Syndrome.

HOW WE CAN FIX THE PROBLEM CAUSED BY THE JAPA SYNDROME

The impact and consequences of Japa syndrome on Nigeria's growth have triggered the need for various solutions to solve the issue. To formulate an approach for overcoming the challenges posed by the Japa Syndrome, it's essential to outline the key strategies and actionable steps that can be taken. Thus, we can tackle the issues arising from the Japa Syndrome through various means that range from creating a favourable business environment, Improving the standard of living, enhancing the educational system, and encouraging diaspora engagement.

The first point to consider in tackling the issues arising from the Japa Syndrome is creating a favourable business environment. In recent years, many professionals and entrepreneurs have sought opportunities abroad due to perceived challenges in the local business landscape. The Nigerian government should implement a series of policy changes aimed at creating a more favourable business environment. This includes infrastructure

development such as improving industrial sectors (such as the health and educational sectors), improving transportation networks, a favourable power supply, a secure environment, and internet connectivity. Thus, by creating a favourable business environment, we will begin to witness a transformation in the business landscape. Some of these include economic growth, job creation, economic opportunities, talent retention, foreign investments, and a strong sense of patriotism. All of which are crucial factors in tackling the issue of the Japa Syndrome.

Another important factor in tackling the issues arising from the Japa Syndrome is improving the standard of living. In a country facing a significant Japa Syndrome, improving the standard of living would be instrumental in mitigating the desire to emigrate. Many citizens migrate to another country due to various reasons such as wage and income disparity, unemployment, limited economic opportunities, lack of basic amenities (such as poor healthcare, poor educational system, unhealthy and unsafe environment), and financial strain. Thus, improving the standard of living is a crucial factor in tackling the issue of the Japa Syndrome for several compelling reasons. By focusing on economic stability, enhancing the quality of life, providing social services, and creating job opportunities and satisfaction, Nigeria can effectively discourage emigration and retain its skilled workforce, contributing to a more prosperous and stable future.

Next, enhancing the educational system is another essential factor in tackling the issues arising from the Japa Syndrome. From my experience, I have realised that the two major reasons people migrate to other countries are for job opportunities and educational purposes. Also, I've realised that travelling abroad is much easier if you're migrating for educational purposes. The question now is: Why do Nigerians prefer studying in a foreign country? Using myself as a case study, I would say that I'd choose to study abroad if there is

no language barrier for various reasons that range from quality of education, specialised programmes, international exposure, diverse career opportunities, a flexible educational system, global certificate recognition, political stability, quality of life, safety and security, and research and training opportunities. These are various reasons why many Nigerians would also prefer studying in foreign countries. Thus, enhancing the educational system is an important factor in tackling the issue of the 'Japa' syndrome for several reasons that range from attracting and retaining talent to fostering innovation and skill development, reducing brain drain, and earning global recognition. In essence, an enhanced educational system can provide the tools, opportunities, and environment needed for Nigerians to achieve their aspirations without leaving the country. This, in turn, can help address the Japa Syndrome by reducing the motivation to emigrate for educational or career purposes.

Finally, an equally significant factor in tackling the issues arising from the Japa Syndrome is encouraging diaspora engagement. Nigeria is a country that values the fundamental human rights of its citizens, including freedom of movement. While many Nigerians have migrated to foreign countries for various reasons, some factors can motivate them to actively participate in the growth of their home country. Thus, encouraging diaspora engagement is a crucial factor in addressing the issue of the 'Japa' syndrome for several reasons. Some of these include skills and knowledge transfer, investment in local ventures, advocacy for policy reforms, collaboration and partnerships, and the potential for return migration. In essence, encouraging diaspora engagement addresses the push factors of the 'Japa' Syndrome by providing economic, social, and cultural incentives to stay connected and actively participate in Nigeria's development. It transforms the narrative from leaving the country for better opportunities to actively contribute to the country's progress, thereby reducing the desire to emigrate.

CONCLUSION

This essay discussed the historical context and the definition of the term 'Japa,' the factors that contribute to the Japa Syndrome, the statistical impact of the Japa Syndrome on the national economy, the consequences of the Japa Syndrome on the national economy, the achievement of the Chartered Institute of Personnel Management in addressing the Japa Syndrome in Nigeria, and how we can solve the problem caused by the Japa Syndrome. Addressing the challenges posed by the 'Japa' syndrome in Nigeria requires a concerted effort not only from the government but also from the private sector and other stakeholders. Thus, by creating a favourable business environment, improving the standard of living, enhancing the educational system, and encouraging diaspora engagement, Nigeria can chart a course towards a brighter future. These strategies offer hope for retaining talent, fostering economic growth, and building a nation where individuals are inspired to stay, contribute, and thrive.

REFERENCES

Abdulateef, B. (2023, February 28). Avoiding brain drain against the “Japa” syndrome.

Retrieved from <https://rubiestech.org/blog/avoiding-brain-drain-against-the-japa-syndrome/>

Ajibade, L. (2023, February 5). "Japa or Sapa" - The Nigerian buzzword of escaping for survival. What does it mean? Retrieved from

<https://coolafricanmerch.com/blogs/coolafricanblog/japa-or-sapa-the-nigerian-buzzword-of-escaping-for-survival-what-does-it-mean#:~:text=What%20Does%20%22Japa%22%20Mean%3F,pursuit%20of%20a%20better%20life>

Bernard, D. (2022). How “Japa” Became the Nigerian buzzword for emigration. Retrieved from <https://www.okayafrica.com/emigration-in-nigeria->

[japa/#:~:text=Colloquially%20known%20as%20%22Japa%22%20%E2%80%94, and %20a%20new%20cultural%20personality](#)

Descasi. (2023, January 19). New Year, Old Challenges – How businesses can solve the Japa syndrome. Retrieved from <https://www.descasio.io/new-year-old-challenges-how-businesses-can-solve-the-japa-syndrome/>

Muhammad, D. A. (2023, February 14). The drive for prosperity: Addressing the Japa syndrome. Daily Trust. Retrieved from <https://dailytrust.com/the-drive-for-prosperity-addressing-the-japa-syndrome/#:~:text=Nigerian%20youths'%20desire%20for%20prosperity,japa'%20of %20the%20Nigerian%20youths.>

Ogungbile, O. (2023, February 7). Nigerians and the Japa syndrome. The Punch. Retrieved from <https://www.google.com/amp/s/punchng.com/nigerians-and-the-japa-syndrome/%3famp>

Okunade, S., & Awosusi, O. (2023). The Japa syndrome and the migration of Nigeria to the United Kingdom: *Journal of Comparative Migration Studies*.

This Day. (n.d.) The burden of Japa Syndrome. Retrieved from <https://www.thisdaylive.com/index.php/2023/05/02/nigeria-and-burden-of-japa-syndrome>

UpGrad Abroad. (2023, September 9). Why study in USA? Top 12 reasons to study in USA. <https://www.upgradabroad.com/articles/why-study-in-usa/>